man that, upon catching sight of Akbar, he leapt off his horse and ran towards the emperor, ready to fall at his feet.

Akbar, too, dismounted to greet his guest. The old man scurrying towards him, his Central Asian features lightly bearded and slightly flushed perhaps, was Akbar's uncle, Mirza[4] Sulaiman, the last of a generation of uncles who had conspired, it would seem, to give Akbar the worst possible start to his career – and the only one who remained, now, to witness his extraordinary rise. The glamour, the pageantry, was for his benefit, for what use is all the world's success if it cannot be flaunted to family?

Sulaiman was satisfyingly overawed, and Akbar was gracious in his majesty, speaking kindly to his aged relative, entertaining him at a banquet, and promising him troops to help him regain his lost kingdom. It was twenty years, at least, since uncle and nephew had met, and it isn't unlikely that the conversation turned to the past. Certainly, Sulaiman, as he marvelled at Akbar's court – the splendour of its gardens and buildings, the profusion of food and drink – must have marvelled, equally, at how things had changed since he last set foot in Hindustan.

That was almost exactly half a century ago. A younger, happier man, Sulaiman was part of the small army that battled Ibrahim Lodi on the plains of Panipat in 1526 and won his own uncle, Babur, a foothold in the north Indian plains. Sulaiman did not remain long in this newly conquered land, however; Babur sent his nephew to govern Badakhshan, and died soon thereafter. As a result, Sulaiman did not witness his family's ignominious reverse migration across the blue waters of the Indus, when, barely fifteen years after that spectacular if all-too-fleeting victory at Panipat, Babur's sons abandoned their father's dreams of empire.

In the fifteen years that followed, however, Sulaiman had not only witnessed but even participated in the bloody and often melodramatic struggles for a kingdom in Kabul between his cousins – Humayun, Kamran, Askari and Hindal. Sometimes, Sulaiman had allied with Kamran, sometimes with Humayun; once, all five young men had formed an optimistic fellowship, planning to march on Samarqand. Sulaiman knew well, besides, how Akbar had spent his childhood hung in the competitive balance between his father and his uncles – how the boy was crowned king when his father died, how he was ruled by regents and challenged by